

INRL20160: The Politics of the EU

Dr. James P. Cross

2025-2026



Introduction

This module draws on a range of political science research on European integration and European Union politics to analyse the development of the EU and how it operates today. The course addresses one of the most important questions in the study of European politics and international organisations: Why did a diverse group of states construct what is currently the world's most extensive example of international integration? The course provides an extensive overview of the contemporary EU, including its institutions and policy-making processes using approaches from modern political science. We will assess how the EU is coping with economic and political challenges to its prosperity and legitimacy. By the end of the module, students will have a thorough grounding in EU politics and the manner in which EU institutions function and cooperate to make policy.

Contact details and office hours

If you have any questions about the course, please consult the syllabus before contacting module instructors.

Points of contact with module instructors

- **Email:** Please put the course code (INRL20160) in subject line of all correspondences.

Lecturer - James Cross: james.cross@ucd.ie

Teaching assistant - Mafalda Zúquete: mafalda.patacaozuquete@ucdconnect.ie

- **Office hours:** If your question remains unanswered via email, office hours on weeks when lectures take place are available by appointment.

Learning Outcomes

Knowledge and Understanding

Following this course students will develop a range of important transferable skills.

Substantive knowledge

By the end of the course, students should be able to:

- Understand and apply the major theories of European integration.
- Understand the contemporary politics of European integration.
- Display knowledge of the objectives and functioning of key EU institutions and policies.
- Critically assess the successes and failures of EU policies.

Skills (Intellectual and Transferable)

The lectures will encourage you to:

- Listen carefully and critically to orally-presented argument
- Develop selective and efficient note-taking methods
- Make links between material presented at different times, on different issues

The written work in the course (policy brief assignment and examination) will require you to:

- Select relevant material from lectures, literature, news sources, and the web
- Understand, analyse and assess that material
- Produce a sustained, structured and informed answer
- Write in a concise and cogent style
- Employ AI tools to improve rather than replace writing skills and outputs

Assessment

Grade component breakdown

1. Policy brief assignment and associated tasks
 - First draft submitted on time - 10% (Pass/Fail)
 - Workshop participation - 10% (Pass/Fail)
 - Final submission - 30% (Graded)
2. Final exam - 50% (Graded)
 - 2x questions answered @ 25% each

Policy brief assignment

This assignment aims to teach you how to provide policy professionals with accessible summaries of research papers published on topics relevant to EU politics. Policy Briefs offer short (**maximum 1000 words in main text**) high-level takes on research and its findings from a policy perspective.

Purpose: To provide a non-expert and time-poor reader with an understanding of the policy context and findings of a piece of research or literature, along with the key policy messages they should take away from it, so that they can hopefully make better use of the research when designing policy.

Assessment focus: The policy brief assignments are intended to assess your substantive knowledge of European integration and apply the insights you have gained from the course to current issues facing the EU and European integration. The relatively short length of the policy brief means that students must prioritise what they include in their text. They need to think carefully about what elements of their argument need to be developed and what elements can be given less attention.

Guidelines for writing a policy brief

There are **three steps** involved in preparing your assignment:

1. Preparing a first draft ahead of the policy brief workshop
2. Taking part in the workshop and revising your draft based on the feedback received
3. Preparing your final submission and submitting it

Assignment timeline:

1. October 10th - First draft submitted via Brightspace
2. Week 6-7 - Policy brief workshops
3. November 7th - Assignment due

Step 1: Preparing your first draft

The first draft serves as the foundation for your final policy brief and is an essential component of the learning process. This initial version should present your core arguments, policy recommendations, and supporting evidence in a structured format, though it need not be perfectly polished. The primary goal is to develop a coherent policy brief that addresses a specific EU-related issue with clear recommendations.

Your first draft will be submitted via Brightspace by October 10th and constitutes 10% of your overall grade on a Pass/Fail basis. A passing grade requires that you submit a complete draft that demonstrates genuine engagement with the assignment requirements and provides sufficient content for meaningful peer review during the workshop phase.

This draft will form the basis for the peer review sessions in the workshop, so ensure it contains substantive content that your peers can provide constructive feedback on. Focus on developing your main arguments and policy recommendations rather than perfecting every detail – the workshop process is designed to help you refine and strengthen your work.

Keep the following in mind when preparing the first draft of your policy brief assignment:

1. **Purpose of the Policy Brief:** Your policy brief should convince its readers of the urgency of a specific issue related to EU politics and advocate for a particular course of action or policy recommendation.
2. **Structure of the policy brief:**
 - **Executive Summary:** Begin with a concise summary of your main findings and recommendations.
 - **Context and Importance:** Detail the current situation, the significance of the issue, and why it matters in the context of EU politics.
 - **Critique of Policy Options:** Analyse existing policy options or interventions, highlighting strengths, weaknesses, and gaps.

- **Policy Recommendations:** Clearly articulate your proposed solutions or actions, backed by empirical evidence, academic research, and clear reasoning.
 - **Bibliography**
 - A full bibliography of works cited is required
 - It does not count towards the word count.
 - **Appendices:**
 - **Appendix 1 (MANDATORY):** Must provide a complete account of all AI tools used to draft the assignment, including specific prompts and explanations of how you used them. See detailed requirements below under “Documenting AI use”.
 - **Appendix 2 (optional):** Can be used to include supplementary information, data, or sources that support your arguments but don’t fit in the main body. Use sparingly and only include relevant materials.
 - **Important:** Appendices do not count towards the 1000-word limit.
3. **Referencing Academic Debates:** Ground your brief in current academic debates and literature. Highlight where your topic fits within these discussions and how it contributes or challenges existing viewpoints.
 4. **Clarity and Conciseness:** Your brief should be well-written, clear, and concise. Avoid jargon; make it accessible for individuals who may not be experts in EU politics (like your future boss!).
 5. **Evidence-Based:** Support your arguments and recommendations with solid evidence. This could come from academic research, reports, surveys, or expert interviews, and be related to EU politics or the policy issue under discussion.
 6. **Audience:** Keep in mind the diverse audience that might read your policy brief. This could range from policymakers, researchers, to the general public interested in EU politics.
 7. **Layout and Presentation:** Use clear headings, bullet points, and possibly charts or illustrations to make your brief visually appealing and easy to navigate. Make sure to cite all data sources appropriately.
 8. **Length:** Aim for no more than 1000 words excluding the bibliography and appendices, ensuring that every word counts and contributes to your overall argument and purpose.

Step 2: Policy brief workshop

In Week 6-7 you will attend a policy-brief workshop in order to improve your first draft. The workshop will provide structured peer feedback and instructor guidance to help you refine your policy brief before final submission.

Workshop Structure:

- **Peer Review Sessions:** You will work in small groups to provide constructive feedback on each other's first drafts, focusing on clarity of arguments, policy recommendations, and use of evidence.
- **Instructor-Led Discussion:** Targeted feedback sessions addressing common issues identified in first drafts, including structure, academic integration, and policy relevance.
- **Revision Planning:** Time allocated to develop a clear revision strategy based on feedback received.

Workshop Participation Requirements:

- **Preparation:** Come prepared with specific questions about your draft and areas where you seek feedback.
- **Active Engagement:** Provide thoughtful, constructive feedback to peers and participate actively in discussions.
- **Documentation:** Keep notes on feedback received to inform your revision process.

Assessment:

Workshop participation constitutes 10% of your overall grade (Pass/Fail). To receive a pass, you must attend the workshop, engage constructively with peer feedback, and demonstrate that you are using the workshop to improve your policy brief.

The workshop feedback should directly inform your final submission revision process, helping you strengthen arguments, improve clarity, and enhance the policy relevance of your brief.

Step 3: Final submission

The following guidelines **must** be followed when preparing your final assignment submission:

- **Word Count:** The main text must be strictly under 1000 words (not 1000+ words).
- **What doesn't count:** Bibliography and appendices are excluded from the 1000-word limit.
- **Mandatory Requirements:**
 - Appendix 1 documenting all AI tool usage (see guidelines below)
 - Complete bibliography of all sources cited
 - Declaration of authorship form (link below)
- **Submission Deadline:** No later than 5 p.m. on 7th November 2025.

- **Extension requests:** Submit here https://docs.google.com/forms/d/e/1FAIpQLScVG2nq0TR1Tc_BMhVg8-10LZS4XoY81N55PrHznByZMzQsmA/viewform?usp=header ahead of deadline.

- **Format:** Submit as PDF via Brightspace only - no hard copy required.
- **Declaration Form:** Must also submit via Brightspace: <https://www.ucd.ie/spire/filestore/School%20Declaration%20of%20Authorship%202022.pdf>

A selection of the best policy brief shall be published (with the author's consent) on the Dublin European Institute's blog found at <https://www.europedebate.ie>. This widely read and highly visible platform provides the opportunity for students to contribute to the public debate about European integration in a concrete manner to a national and international audience. It also allows students to publicly demonstrate their mastery of their chosen topic in a professional context, and as such represents a great opportunity to build a profile for future employers be they in academia, the public sector or the private sector.

Use of AI Tools

This module encourages the thoughtful use of AI tools as learning partners to deepen your understanding of EU politics. **See the comprehensive AI guidance section at the end of this document for detailed instructions on how to use AI effectively for learning, quality assurance frameworks, and documentation requirements.** All AI use must comply with UCD's academic integrity policies: <https://libguides.ucd.ie/academicintegrity>.

Enhanced Documentation Requirements for Appendix 1:

- All AI interactions must be documented in tabular format in a mandatory Appendix 1
- AI should enhance your critical thinking, not replace it
- All AI-generated insights must be verified against independent sources
- Focus on using AI for exploration, analysis, and refinement rather than answer generation

Your AI appendix must demonstrate learning, not just usage. For each AI interaction, you must document:

Mandatory Reflection Questions:

- How did your AI interactions change your understanding of the topic?
- What questions did AI help you formulate that you wouldn't have asked otherwise?
- Which AI suggestions did you reject, and why?
- How did you verify AI-generated insights against academic sources?

AI Tool	Learning Purpose	Key Prompts	What You Learned
ChatGPT	Exploring democratic deficit arguments	“What are the strongest critiques of EU democratic legitimacy?”	Identified 3 main theoretical frameworks I hadn’t considered; led me to Follesdal & Hix (2006)
Claude	Testing my policy argument	“I argue X about EU migration policy. What are the counter-arguments?”	Realised my argument ignored economic impacts; strengthened by adding economic evidence

Table 1: Enhanced AI Learning Log Template

Policy brief grading rubric

The following guidelines should be adhered to when writing your policy brief. The rubric is also useful for structuring your thoughts when preparing your policy brief.

- **Statement of Purpose/ Focus and Organisation - 30%**

- The response is fully sustained and consistently and purposefully focused:
 - * Claims are clearly stated, focused, and strongly maintained
 - * Claims are introduced and communicated appropriately for the purpose, audience, and task
 - * Alternate or opposing claims are clearly addressed
- The response has a clear and effective organisational structure creating unity and completeness:
 - * A variety of transitional strategies is consistently used to effectively clarify the relationships between and among ideas
 - * The progression of ideas from beginning to end is logical
 - * The introduction and conclusion are effective for audience and purpose
 - * Appropriate sentence structure variety produce strong connection between ideas

- **Evidence/Elaboration - 30%**

- The response provides thorough and convincing support/evidence for the writer’s claim that includes the effective use of sources, facts, and details. The response achieves substantial depth that is specific and relevant:
 - * Claims are supported with relevant evidence from credible sources and clear reasoning
 - * Use of evidence from sources is smoothly integrated, cited, comprehensive, and concrete
 - * A variety of effective argumentative techniques is used
- The response demonstrates strategic use of language to produce clear communication:

- * Precise language clearly and effectively expresses ideas
- * The use of academic and domain-specific vocabulary is clearly appropriate for the audience and purpose
- **Editing Conventions - 20%**
 - The response displays adequate command of all grade level and preceding level conventions of writing:
 - * Some errors in usage and sentence formation may be present, but no systematic pattern of errors is displayed
 - * The use of punctuation, capitalisation, and spelling is adequate
- **AI use and documentation - 20%**
 - The response demonstrates responsible and learning-centred AI usage with comprehensive documentation evidencing the following:
 - * Complete documentation of all AI interactions in mandatory appendix, including specific tools, prompts, and learning purposes
 - * Clear evidence that AI was used to enhance critical thinking and understanding of EU politics rather than replace intellectual engagement
 - * All AI-generated insights are verified against independent academic sources and properly attributed
 - * Thoughtful reflection on how AI interactions changed understanding and contributed to learning outcomes

End of year exam - 50%

There will be an exam at the end of the semester. This examination will constitute 50% of your final mark. This will either be an in-person or take-home exam depending on the covid-19 restrictions in place at the time. Example exams demonstrating the structure and requirements of the end of year exam will be distributed in due course.

There will be **6 questions** on the exam and you have to **answer 2** of them.

Course reading

Required readings:

The following texts shall be used extensively throughout the course, so it is recommended that you get access to them.

- Cini, M. and Borragán, N.P.S. 2025. European Union Politics. Oxford University Press. 8th ed.
- Hix, S. and Høyland, B. 2022. The Political System of the European Union. Palgrave Macmillan. 4th Ed.

Recommended Readings

The following books provide a general overview of the topics that will be covered in this module.

- Wallace, H., Pollack, M.A. and Young, A.R. eds. 2015. Policy-making in the European Union. Oxford University Press, USA.
- Bomberg, E., Peterson, J. and Corbett, R. 2012. The European Union: how does it work?. Oxford University Press.
- Bache, I., Bulmer, S., George, S. and Parker, O. 2014. Politics in the European Union. Oxford University Press, USA.
- Hix, S. 2013. What's Wrong with the Europe Union and How to Fix it. John Wiley & Sons.
- Majone, G. 2009. Dilemmas of European integration: the ambiguities and pitfalls of integration by stealth. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Peterson, J. and Shackleton, M. 2012. The institutions of the European Union. Oxford University Press.
- Thomson, R. 2011. Resolving controversy in the European Union: legislative decision-making before and after enlargement. Cambridge University Press.
- Wiener, A. and Diez, T. 2009. European integration theory. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

In addition to these readings, students should keep up to date on current European affairs by reading daily newspapers, or one of the many websites devoted to EU politics. This reading is essential as it will allow you to keep up to date with current affairs in the EU and identify potential policy brief topics. These websites include the following:

- <https://euobserver.com>
- <https://europa.eu>
- <http://www.eupolitics.com>
- <https://www.ft.com>
- <https://blogs.lse.ac.uk/europpblog/>
- <https://blogs.lse.ac.uk/brexit/>

Brightspace

Please make sure you have access to the module in Brightspace as soon as possible. It is the student's responsibility to make sure that they are signed up to the module correctly and they know how to submit coursework through the appropriate Brightspace assignment tab. If you have any issues with Brightspace contact the Brightspace support people to resolve the issue.

Furthermore, module materials such as this syllabus and announcements made outside lectures shall be on Brightspace. As such, Brightspace is an important communication tool for the module.

Detailed course programme

Week 1

Introduction and the history of European integration

Study questions

- What are the major challenges, threats, and opportunities facing the EU today? How do you think these issues will affect the EU and shape its future?
- What are the main milestones that the integration process in Europe went through?
- How has the European integration project developed over time and how has the policy remit of the EU evolved?
- How have global events and geopolitical shifts influenced the EU's objectives and policies?
- What have been the key drivers of enlargement and deeper integration within the EU?
- Can you identify any points in history where the EU could have taken a different developmental path? What might have been the outcomes?

Key reading

- Cini, M. and Borragán, N.P.S. 2025. European Union Politics. Oxford University Press. Chapter 1-3.

Further reading

- Hix, S. and Høyland, B. 2022. The Political System of the European Union. Palgrave Macmillan. Chapter 1.
- Urwin, D.W. 2014. The community of Europe: A history of European integration since 1945. Routledge.
- Dinan, D. 2010. Ever Closer Union: An Introduction to European Integration. London: Palgrave Macmillan. Chapters 1-6.

- Marks, G. 2011. Europe and Its Empires: From Rome to the European Union. *Journal of Common Market Studies* 50(1), pp.1-20.
- Nugent, N. 2010. *The Government and Politics of the European Union*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan, Part 1: Chapters 1-7.
- Bache, I. and George, S. 2011. *Politics in the European Union*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, Chapters 5-11.
- Diebold, W. 1959. *The Schuman Plan*. New York: Praeger.
- Dougan, M. 2008. The Treaty of Lisbon 2007: Winning Minds not Hearts. *Common Market Law Review* 45, pp.617–703.
- Gray, M. and Stubb, A. 2001. Keynote Article: The Treaty of Nice—Negotiating a Poisoned Chalice?. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 39(s1), pp.5-23.
- Magnette, P. and Nicolaidis, K. 2004. The European Convention: bargaining in the shadow of rhetoric. *West European Politics*, 27(3), pp.381-404.
- Majone, G. 2006. The Common Sense of European Integration. *Journal of European Public Policy* 13(5), pp.607-626.
- Piris, J-C. 2010. *The Lisbon Treaty: a legal and political analysis*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Week 2

Theories of European integration

Study questions

- Describe the main logic behind neofunctionalism as a theory of European integration. Can this theory successfully explain how we got to where we are now in terms of EU integration?
- Describe the main logic behind intergovernmentalism. Does this theory do a better job of explaining the European integration project than neofunctionalism?
- What are the strengths and weaknesses of both theories of integration?
- What are the three different types of institutionalism? How do they differ from one another?
- How do institutionalist theories differ from the ‘grand’ theories of integration that went before?
- How successful are institutionalist theories at explaining EU politics?
- Are there any recent developments or crises in the EU that challenge the premises of these theories?
- How have institutionalist theories evolved to account for the complexities and nuances of modern EU politics?

Key reading

- Cini, M. and Pérez-Solórzano Borragán, N. (eds.) 2025. *European Union Politics*, Oxford: Oxford University Press. Chapters 4-5.
- Moravcsik, A. 1993. Preferences and Power in the European Community. *Journal of Common Market Studies* 31(4), pp.473-524.
- Aspinwall, M. and Schneider, G. 2000. Same Menu, Separate Tables: The Institutional Turn in Political Science and the Study of European Integration. *European Journal of Political Research* 38, pp.1-36.

Further reading

- Hooghe, L., Marks, G., 2019. Grand theories of European integration in the twenty-first century. *Journal of European Public Policy* 26, 1113–1133. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13501763.2019.1569711>
- Rauh, C., 2019. Between neo-functionalist optimism and post-functionalist pessimism: Integrating politicisation into integration theory.
- Carstensen, M.B., Schmidt, V.A., 2016. Power through, over and in ideas: conceptualizing ideational power in discursive institutionalism. *Journal of European Public Policy* 23, 318–337. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13501763.2015.1115534>
- Hoffmann, S. 1966. Obstinate or obsolete? The fate of the nation-state and the case of Western Europe. *Daedalus*, pp.862-915.
- Haas, E.B. 1976. Turbulent Fields and the Theory of Regional Integration. *International Organization* 30, pp.173-212.
- Monnet, J. 1978. *Memoirs*. New York: Doubleday.
- Bache, I. and George, S. 2011. *Politics in the European Union*. Oxford: Oxford University Press, Chapter 1.
- Haas, E.B. 1958. *The Uniting of Europe*. Stanford: Stanford University Press.
- Haas, E.B. 1961. International Integration: The European and Universal Process. *International Organization* 15(3), pp.366-92.
- Haas, E.B. 1975. *The Obsolescence of Regional Integration Theory*. Berkeley: Institute of International Studies.
- Hooghe, L and Marks G. 2001. *Multi-Level Governance and European Integration*. Oxford: Rowman and Littlefield.
- Jupille, J. and Caporaso, J.A. 1999. Institutionalism and the European Union: Beyond Comparative Politics and International Relations. *Annual Review Political Science* 2, pp.429-44.
- Moravcsik, A. 1998. *The Choice For Europe: Social Purpose And State Power From Messina To Maastricht*. Cornell University Press, Chapter 1, 7.

- Nugent, N. 2010. *The Government and Politics of the European Union*. London: Palgrave Macmillan, Chapter 23.
- Pollack, M.A. 2003. *The Engines of European Integration: Delegation, Agency and Agenda Setting in the EU*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Pollock, M.A. 2005. Theorizing the EU: International Organization, Domestic Polity, or Experiment in New Governance? *Annual Review Political Science*. 8, pp.357–98.
- Rosamond, B. 2000. *Theories of European Integration* London: MacMillan, Chapters 2 and 3.
- Sandholtz, W. And Sweet Stone, A. 1998. *European Integration and Supranational Governance*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Weiner, A. and Diez, T. 2009. *European Integration Theory*. Oxford: Oxford University Press (2nd Edition).
- Hooghe, L. and Marks, G. 2009. A Postfunctionalist Theory of European Integration: From Permissive Consensus to Constraining Dissensus. *British Journal of Political Science* 39(1), pp.1-23.
- Pierson P. 1996., The path to European Integration: An Historical Institutional Perspective. *Comparative Political Studies*. 29(2), pp.123-63.
- Tsebelis, G. and Garrett, G. 2001., The Institutional Foundations of Intergovernmentalism and Supranationalism. *International Organization* 55(2), pp.357-90.
- Bickerton, C.J., Hodson, D. and Puetter, U. 2014. The new intergovernmentalism: European integration in the post-Maastricht era. *Journal of Common Market Studies* 53(4), pp.703–22.
- Schimmelfennig, F. 2015a. What’s the news in ‘new intergovernmentalism’? A critique of Bickerton, Hodson and Puetter. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies* 53(4), pp.723–30.
- Schimmelfennig, F. 2015. Liberal intergovernmentalism and the euro area crisis. *Journal of European Public Policy*, 22(2), pp.177-195.
- Puetter, U. 2016. The centrality of consensus and deliberation in contemporary EU politics and the new intergovernmentalism. *Journal of European Integration*, 38(5), pp.601-615.
- Puetter, U. and Fabbrini, S. 2016. Catalysts of integration—the role of core intergovernmental forums in EU politics. *Journal of European Integration*, 38(5), pp.633-642.
- Kleine, M., and Pollack, M. 2018. Liberal Intergovernmentalism and Its Critics. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1493–1509.
- Moravcsik, A. 2018. Preferences, Power and Institutions in 21st-century Europe. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1648-1674.

- Meunier, S., and Vachudova, M. A. 2018. Liberal Intergovernmentalism, Illiberalism and the Potential Superpower of the European Union. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1631–1647.
- Hix, S. 2018. When Optimism Fails: Liberal Intergovernmentalism and Citizen Representation. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1595–1613.
- Schimmelfennig, F. 2018. Liberal Intergovernmentalism and the Crises of the European Union. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1578–1594.
- Schimmelfennig, F. 2018. European integration (theory) in times of crisis. A comparison of the Euro and Schengen crises, *Journal of European Public Policy*, 25(7), pp.969–989
- Schmidt, V. A. 2018. Rethinking EU Governance: From Old to New Approaches to Who Steers Integration. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1544–1561.
- Naurin, D. 2018. Liberal Intergovernmentalism in the Councils of the EU: A Baseline Theory?. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1526–1543.
- McNamara, K. R. 2018. Authority Under Construction: The European Union in Comparative Political Perspective. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56, pp.1510–1525.
- Jones, E. 2018. Towards a theory of disintegration, *Journal of European Public Policy*, 25(3), pp.440–451.
- Rauh, C., 2019. Between neo-functionalist optimism and post-functionalist pessimism: Integrating politicisation into integration theory. Working paper.
- Genschel, P. and Jachtenfuchs, M., 2018. From market integration to core state powers: the Eurozone crisis, the refugee crisis and integration theory. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 56(1), pp.178–196.

Week 3

Executive politics

Study questions

- How is the European Council structured? What strengths and weaknesses arise from this structure in terms of its ability to influence the direction of the EU?
- How is the European Commission structured? How does it fit into the institutional structure of the EU?
- Does the institutional structure of the Commission help or hinder its ability to make policy?
- What roles do the European Council and Commission play in the political system of the EU? How do their roles differ?
- Explain principle-agent theory. Does this theory successfully describe the sources of Commission power and influence in EU politics?

- How do the European Council and the European Commission collaborate or conflict in setting EU policies?
- How have the roles and powers of these institutions evolved in response to crises or major policy shifts?
- What impact do changes in the leadership of the European Council and Commission have on EU policy direction?

Key reading

- Cini, M. and Borragán, N.P.S. 2025. *European Union Politics*. Oxford University Press. Chapters 9, Chapter 10 (part about European Council)
- Hix, S. and Høyland, B. 2022. *The political system of the European Union*. Palgrave Macmillan. Chapter 2.
- Pollack, M A. 1997. Delegation, Agency, and Agenda Setting in the European Community. *International Organization* 51(1), pp.99–134.

Further reading

- Anastasopoulos, L.J., Bertelli, A.M., 2020. Understanding Delegation Through Machine Learning: A Method and Application to the European Union. *American Political Science Review* 114, 291–301. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0003055419000522>
- Frieden, J., Walter, S., 2019. Analyzing inter-state negotiations in the Eurozone crisis and beyond. *European Union Politics* 20, 134–151. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1465116518813450>
- Pircher, B., Farjam, M., 2021. Oppositional voting in the Council of the EU between 2010 and 2019: Evidence for differentiated politicisation. *European Union Politics* 22, 472–494. <https://doi.org/10.1177/14651165211004754>
- Rauh, C., 2021. One agenda-setter or many? The varying success of policy initiatives by individual Directorates-General of the European Commission 1994–2016. *European Union Politics* 22, 3–24. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1465116520961467>
- Vaznonytė, A., 2020. The rotating Presidency of the Council of the EU–Still an agenda-setter?. *European Union Politics*, 21(3) pp.497–518.
- Hobolt, S.B. and Wratil, C., 2020. Contestation and responsiveness in EU Council deliberations. *Journal of European Public Policy*, 27(3), pp.362–381.
- Rauh, C. 2019. EU politicization and policy initiatives of the European Commission: the case of consumer policy, *Journal of European Public Policy*, 26(3), pp.344–365
- Delreux, T. and Adriaensen, J. eds., 2017. *The Principal Agent Model and the European Union*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Delreux, T. and Adriaensen, J. 2017. Twenty years of principal-agent research in EU politics: how to cope with complexity?. *European Political Science*, pp.1–18.

- Conceição-Heldt, E. 2010. Who controls whom? Dynamics of power delegation and agency losses in EU trade politics. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*, 48(4), pp.1107-1126.
- Nugent, N. and Rhinard, M. 2016. Is the European Commission Really in Decline?. *JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies*. 54(5), pp.1199-1215.
- Brown, S.A. 2016. The Commission and the Crisis: Chief Loser or Unexpected Winner?. In *The European Commission and Europe's Democratic Process*, pp.69-78. Palgrave Macmillan UK.
- Bauer, M.W. and Becker S. 2014. The unexpected winner of the crisis: the European Commission's strengthened role in economic governance. *Journal of European Integration*. 36(3), pp.213-29.
- da Conceição-Heldt, E. 2016. Why the European Commission is not the "unexpected winner" of the Euro crisis: A comment on Bauer and Becker. *Journal of European Integration*, 38(1), pp.95-100.
- Bauer, M.W. and Becker, S. 2016. Absolute Gains Are Still Gains: Why the European Commission Is a Winner of the Crisis, and Unexpectedly So. A Rejoinder to Eugénia da Conceição-Heldt. *Journal of European Integration*, 38(1), pp.101-106.
- Fabbrini, S. and Puetter, U. 2016. Integration without supranationalisation: studying the lead roles of the European Council and the Council in post-Lisbon EU politics. *Journal of European Integration*, 38(5), pp.481-495.
- Bailer, S. 2014. An Agent Dependent on the EU Member States? The Determinants of the European Commission's Legislative Success in the European Union, *Journal of European Integration*, 36(1), pp.37-53.
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Week 4 and Week 5

Legislative politics

Study questions

- Describe the different legislative procedures used in the EU. How do they differ from one another?
- Describe the internal structure of the Council of Ministers. How are legislative powers and influence distributed between 1) the member states in terms of voting power? and 2) between the different levels of negotiation within the Council?
- Describe the internal structure of the European Parliament. What are the main dimensions of political conflict in the EP? How stable are coalitions between the EP party groups?
- What are some real-world examples where the legislative procedure significantly influenced the outcome of a policy?
- How have changes in the balance of power among EU institutions impacted legislative processes?

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Week 6

Judicial politics and compliance

Study questions

- Describe the structure of the European Court of Justice and the different procedures the ECJ has at its disposal to enforce EU law?
- What role does the European Court of Justice play in the political system of the EU? What powers does it yield and what are the limits of these powers?
- What do we mean by the term ‘judicial activism’? Does the ECJ engage in judicial activism often? How have member states reacted to examples of judicial activism by the ECJ?
- What difficulties might arise when Member States transpose EU laws into national laws?
- We observe significant variation in the levels of compliance with EU law both between Member States and over time. What can explain this variation?
- Why might member states fail to comply with EU legislation? What incentives are involved in compliance and non-compliance?
- How do ECJ decisions interact with national legal systems, and what challenges arise from this interaction?
- How has the role of the ECJ evolved in the context of expanding EU competencies?
- Can you identify any landmark ECJ cases that had a significant impact on EU integration or member state relations?

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Week 7

Elections, referenda, and public opinion

Study questions

- How has public opinion towards the EU changed over time? What explains this variation?
- What different theories have attempted to explain public attitudes towards the EU? Which of these theories is most convincing and why?
- What do we mean when we describe the EP elections as second order in nature? Is this a fair description of EP elections at this point in the history of the EU?

- How do national events or crises impact public opinion about the EU? Can you provide examples?
- How do political parties within member states influence public opinion about the EU?
- Is voter turnout in EP elections indicative of public interest and opinion toward the EU? Why or why not?

Key reading

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Week 8

Reading week - no lectures

Week 9

Interest representation

Study questions

- What are interest groups and why do we study them in the EU context?

- Describe the different access point through which lobbyists attempt to influence EU policy making. Do the institutional structures of the Commission, EP, and Council aid or hinder lobbyists in their lobbying attempts?
- What different types of factors have been identified as influencing lobbying success in the EU?
- What attempts have been made to regulate EU lobbying? Have these attempts been successful?
- How do interest groups and lobbyists contribute to or challenge the democratic legitimacy of the EU?
- Can you identify any landmark lobbying campaigns that have significantly impacted EU policy?

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Week 10

Brexit

Study questions

- What factors explain the outcome of the Brexit referendum vote?
- What factors explain the outcome of the Brexit negotiations between the UK and the EU?
- How has Ireland, a much small country than the UK, managed to have its views enshrined in the withdrawal agreement?
- How is Brexit (if it goes ahead) likely to affect EU decision-making?
- How have the Brexit negotiations impacted the relationships between EU member states?
- What are the long-term implications of Brexit for the EU's policy agenda?
- How has Brexit influenced public opinion about the EU in both the UK and the remaining member states?

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Week 11

The EU's democratic deficit and EU transparency

Study questions

- What is a democratic deficit? Does the EU suffer from a lack of democratic legitimacy? Should we hold the EU to the same ideals of democratic legitimacy as we do nation states?
- How transparent is the EU? How has this changed over time? Is increasing transparency a potential way in which to make the EU more democratic and legitimate?
- How do the principles and practices of subsidiarity and proportionality relate to the democratic legitimacy of the EU?
- What role do the media and public opinion play in enhancing or undermining the EU's democratic legitimacy?
- Has the EU made significant strides in improving its transparency, and what challenges remain?

Key reading

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Week 12

Revision and exam preparation

AI as a Learning Partner: Enhanced Guidelines

Philosophy: AI for Deep Learning, Not Quick Answers

Generative AI tools should enhance your critical thinking and understanding of EU politics, not replace it. This section provides a framework for using AI as an intellectual partner that deepens your engagement with course material while maintaining the highest academic standards.

Core Principle: Use AI to ask better questions, explore complex ideas, and develop stronger arguments—not to generate ready-made answers.

Learning-Centred AI - A 3-stage process for using AI to support learning

Stage 1: Exploration & Discovery

- **Purpose:** Use AI to explore topics, identify knowledge gaps, and generate research directions
- **Learning Objective:** Develop curiosity and identify areas for deeper investigation
- **Example Prompts:**
 - “What are the most contested aspects of EU democratic legitimacy, and why do scholars disagree?”
 - “Help me understand the different perspectives on Brexit’s impact on EU integration theory”
 - “What questions should I be asking about the EU’s response to migration?”
- **Critical Task:** Always ask yourself: “What don’t I understand yet? What assumptions am I making?”

Stage 2: Analysis & Argument Development

- **Purpose:** Use AI to test arguments, explore counterarguments, and refine analytical thinking
- **Learning Objective:** Strengthen argumentation skills and consider multiple perspectives
- **Example Prompts:**
 - “I argue that [your position]. What are the strongest counterarguments to this view?”
 - “Help me identify weaknesses in this policy recommendation: [your idea]”
 - “What evidence would I need to support the claim that [specific EU policy] has been effective?”
- **Critical Task:** Engage with AI responses critically—don’t accept them at face value

Stage 3: Refinement & Quality Control

- **Purpose:** Use AI to improve clarity, identify gaps, and enhance presentation
- **Learning Objective:** Develop self-editing skills and professional writing standards
- **Example Prompts:**
 - “Is my argument clear and logically structured? Where could it be strengthened?”
 - “What important perspectives or evidence am I missing from this analysis?”
 - “How can I make this policy recommendation more actionable and specific?”
- **Critical Task:** Maintain your voice and perspective—AI should enhance, not replace your ideas

Quality Assurance: Evaluating AI Output

Before incorporating any AI-generated content or insights, you should consider applying the following evaluation framework to assess the quality and usefulness of the outputs generated:

Reliability Check:

1. **Source Verification:** Can you find independent sources that support these claims?
2. **Logical Consistency:** Do the arguments make sense within the context of the course content and broader research on EU politics?
3. **Currency Check:** Is this information up-to-date and relevant to current EU developments?
4. **Perspective Balance:** Does the response represent multiple viewpoints or just one angle?

Red Flags - When AI Output May Be Unreliable:

- Specific statistics without clear sources
- Claims about recent events without verification
- Oversimplified explanations of complex EU processes
- Definitive statements about contentious political issues
- Citations that you cannot independently verify

EU Politics-Specific AI Strategies

For Policy Analysis:

- Use AI to explore policy trade-offs: “What are the unintended consequences of [EU policy]?”
- Test institutional analysis: “How might different EU institutions view this issue differently?”
- Examine how a policy might be affected by multi-level governance considerations: “How does this policy affect national, EU, and subnational levels?”

For Theory Application:

- Test theoretical frameworks: “How would neofunctionalist theory explain [current EU development]?”
- Compare theoretical predictions: “Where do liberal intergovernmentalism and neofunctionalism disagree on this issue?”
- Explore theoretical evolution: “How have theories of European integration adapted to recent crises?”

Recommended AI Tools by Learning Function

Deep Learning & Analysis:

- ChatGPT: <https://chat.openai.com> - Complex reasoning and argument development
- Claude: <https://claude.ai/chat> - Critical analysis and counterargument generation
- Perplexity: <https://www.perplexity.ai> - Research synthesis with source verification

Academic Research:

- Elicit: <https://elicit.org> - Literature discovery and research question formulation
- Semantic Scholar: <https://www.semanticscholar.org> - Academic source identification
- SciSpace: <https://typeset.io> - Paper analysis and concept explanation

Writing & Communication:

- Grammarly: <https://www.grammarly.com> - Language clarity and professional tone
- Quillbot: <https://quillbot.com/> - Paraphrasing and style improvement
- Jenni: <https://jenni.ai> - Academic writing structure and flow

Academic Integrity & AI

All AI use must comply with UCD's academic integrity policies: <https://libguides.ucd.ie/academicintegrity>

Acceptable AI Use:

- Brainstorming and idea exploration
- Argument testing and refinement
- Language improvement and clarity enhancement
- Research direction identification
- Critical analysis development

Unacceptable AI Use:

- Direct copy-paste of AI-generated text without attribution
- Using AI to write complete sections without intellectual engagement
- Relying on AI for factual claims without independent verification
- Using AI to avoid engaging with course readings and materials

Remember:

The goal is to become a more sophisticated thinker about EU politics, not just to complete assignments efficiently. AI should challenge your thinking, not replace it.